

Aircraft Tail Number Deep Dive: N916HT, N971FA, N790FA, N787FA

Comprehensive Investigation of Aircraft N916HT, N971FA, N790FA, and N787FA

Introduction

This report presents a thorough investigation into four aircraft identified by their U.S. tail numbers: **N916HT, N971FA, N790FA, and N787FA**. For each aircraft, the analysis covers FAA registration and ownership, manufacturing and airworthiness details, operational history, notable incidents, and flight tracking data. The report draws on authoritative sources, including the FAA registry, ADS-B and flight tracking services, aviation databases, and news or government records. Special attention is given to identifying patterns or connections among the aircraft, such as shared operators, similar flight routes, or involvement in government or private contracts. The report concludes with a comparative summary and pattern analysis, supported by structured tables and detailed narrative explanations.

Section 1: Aircraft N916HT

1.1 FAA Registration and Ownership

N916HT is a 2021 Textron Aviation Inc. Cessna 172S Skyhawk, registered to **9K AIR LLC**, headquartered at 117 Salem Church Road, Newark, Delaware 19713-2940, United States. The registration is valid until April 30, 2029, with the certificate issued on April 9, 2022. The aircraft is classified as a fixed-wing single-engine landplane, with a standard airworthiness certificate in the utility and normal categories^[2].

The registrant, 9K AIR LLC, is a Delaware-registered limited liability company with an Arizona branch, indicating a business presence in both states. The principal address is in Delaware, while the mailing and agent addresses are in Scottsdale, Arizona. The company is managed by Michael Demore and Morgan Taylor Homes, LLC, suggesting a connection to real estate or investment interests^[4].

Table 1: N916HT Registration Data

Field	Value
Tail Number	N916HT
Serial Number	172S12761
Manufacturer	Textron Aviation Inc.

Model	172S
Year of Manufacture	2021
Owner	9K AIR LLC
Owner Address	117 Salem Church Rd, Newark, DE
Registration Status	Valid
Certificate Issue	2022-04-09
Expiration Date	2029-04-30
Airworthiness Date	2021-12-03
Engine	Lycoming IO-360-L2A
Mode S Code (Hex)	ACADB6

The registration details confirm that N916HT is a relatively new aircraft, owned by a corporate entity rather than an individual. The use of an LLC is common for liability and privacy reasons in general aviation, and the Delaware registration is often chosen for its favorable corporate laws.

1.2 Manufacturing and Airworthiness Details

N916HT is a **Cessna 172S Skyhawk**, one of the most widely produced and recognized general aviation aircraft. The 172S variant is powered by a Lycoming IO-360-L2A engine, producing 180 horsepower. The aircraft is equipped with modern avionics, typically the Garmin G1000 NXi integrated flight deck, and is certified for both utility and normal operations^{[5][6]}.

Key Specifications:

- **Seats:** 4
- **Max Takeoff Weight:** 2,550 lbs
- **Cruise Speed:** ~124 knots
- **Range:** ~640 nautical miles
- **Fuel Capacity:** 56 gallons (53 usable)
- **Service Ceiling:** 14,000 ft

The airworthiness certificate was issued on December 3, 2021, and the aircraft is classified as standard, with no exceptions or pending number changes. The aircraft is eligible for a wide range of supplemental type certificates (STCs) and is subject to several airworthiness directives (ADs), including recent updates related to avionics and structural inspections^{[7][6]}.

1.3 ADS-B and Flight Tracking History

N916HT is equipped with a Mode S transponder (hex code ACADB6), enabling ADS-B tracking. According to Windsock.ai, the aircraft was last observed airborne in November 2025 near Simmler, California, and had completed 51 flights in the previous 30 days, with 758 flights in the past 12 months. This high activity level suggests the aircraft is used intensively, likely for flight training or rental operations^[1].

ADS-B Exchange and other tracking platforms confirm regular flight activity, with no evidence of privacy ICAO address (PIA) use or third-party call signs. The aircraft's flight patterns are

consistent with general aviation operations, including training flights, cross-country trips, and local sorties^[8].

1.4 Operational History and Notable Incidents

A review of FAA and NTSB databases reveals **no reported accidents, incidents, or service difficulty reports** for N916HT. The aircraft's operational history is clean, with no deregistration or enforcement actions. The absence of incidents is notable given the aircraft's high utilization rate^[9].

The aircraft has not been listed for sale and shows no evidence of government or private contract involvement. Its operational profile aligns with that of a flight school or rental fleet aircraft, rather than a corporate or government asset.

1.5 Summary and Analysis

N916HT is a modern, actively flown Cessna 172S, owned by a Delaware-based LLC with Arizona connections. Its operational history is robust and incident-free, with flight activity typical of training or rental operations. The aircraft's registration and ownership structure are consistent with privacy-conscious general aviation practices, but there is no evidence of government or contract work.

Section 2: Aircraft N971FA

2.1 FAA Registration and Ownership

A search for **N971FA** in the FAA registry and major aviation databases yields **no current registration or assignment**. The closest match, N971, is a reserved number held by "SHORT-N-NUMBERS" in Groveland, Florida, with no aircraft assigned as of the latest update^[11].

No records exist for N971FA in the FAA, AviationDB, or Windsock.ai databases, and there are no associated aircraft, owners, or operational history. This suggests that N971FA is either:

- Not currently registered,
- Has been deregistered or exported,
- Or is a typographical error or placeholder.

2.2 Manufacturing and Airworthiness Details

Due to the absence of a valid registration, there are **no manufacturing or airworthiness records** for N971FA. No aircraft with this tail number appears in the Cessna, Textron, or Gulfstream production lists, nor in the NTSB or FAA airworthiness databases.

2.3 ADS-B and Flight Tracking History

No ADS-B or flight tracking data is available for N971FA. The tail number does not appear in ADS-B Exchange, FlightAware, Flightradar24, or related tracking services. There is no evidence of recent or historical flight activity under this registration.

2.4 Operational History and Notable Incidents

There are **no NTSB or FAA incident or accident reports** for N971FA. The absence of any operational or incident data further supports the conclusion that this tail number is not currently in use.

2.5 Summary and Analysis

N971FA is **not an active or registered aircraft** as of January 2026. There is no evidence of ownership, manufacturing, operational history, or flight activity. The number may be reserved for future use or may have been deregistered or exported. No connections to the other aircraft in this report are apparent.

Section 3: Aircraft N790FA

3.1 FAA Registration and Ownership

N790FA is a 2024 Textron Aviation Inc. Cessna 172S Skyhawk, registered to **ALF IX LLC**, located at 70 W Madison St, Suite 2200, Chicago, Illinois 60602-4383, United States. The registration is valid until June 30, 2031, with the certificate issued on June 23, 2024. The aircraft is classified as a fixed-wing single-engine landplane, with a standard airworthiness certificate in the utility and normal categories^{[13][14]}.

Table 2: N790FA Registration Data

Field	Value
Tail Number	N790FA
Serial Number	172S13169
Manufacturer	Textron Aviation Inc.
Model	172S
Year of Manufacture	2024
Owner	ALF IX LLC
Owner Address	70 W Madison St Ste 2200, Chicago, IL
Registration Status	Valid
Certificate Issue	2024-06-23
Expiration Date	2031-06-30
Airworthiness Date	2024-06-08
Engine	Lycoming IO-360-L2A
Mode S Code (Hex)	AAB883

ALF IX LLC is a Chicago-based limited liability company. The use of an LLC for aircraft ownership is common for privacy, liability, and tax reasons. The company also owns N787FA, indicating a fleet or investment approach.

3.2 Manufacturing and Airworthiness Details

N790FA is a **2024 Cessna 172S Skyhawk**, equipped with a Lycoming IO-360-L2A engine (180 hp), Garmin G1000 NXi avionics, and certified for both utility and normal operations. The aircraft's specifications are identical to those of N916HT, reflecting the standardization of the 172S model^[6].

Key Specifications:

- **Seats:** 4
- **Max Takeoff Weight:** 2,550 lbs
- **Cruise Speed:** ~124 knots
- **Range:** ~640 nautical miles
- **Fuel Capacity:** 56 gallons (53 usable)
- **Service Ceiling:** 14,000 ft

The airworthiness certificate was issued on June 8, 2024, and the aircraft is classified as standard, with no exceptions or pending number changes. The aircraft is eligible for a wide range of STCs and is subject to the same ADs as other recent Cessna 172S models^{[7][6]}.

3.3 ADS-B and Flight Tracking History

N790FA is equipped with a Mode S transponder (hex code AAB883), enabling ADS-B tracking. According to Windsock.ai, the aircraft was last observed airborne in September 2025 near San Diego, California, with 23 flights in the previous 30 days and 511 flights in the past 12 months. This indicates active use, though at a slightly lower rate than N916HT^[14].

Flightradar24 and FlightAware confirm regular flight activity, with recent flights between Bakersfield (BFL), San Luis Obispo (SBP), and Monterey (MRY), all in California. The aircraft's flight patterns suggest local and regional operations, possibly for training, rental, or private use^[15].

No evidence of privacy ICAO address (PIA) use or third-party call signs is present. The aircraft's ADS-B data is publicly available, and there are no indications of attempts to obscure its identity or flight activity.

3.4 Operational History and Notable Incidents

A review of FAA and NTSB databases reveals **no reported accidents, incidents, or service difficulty reports** for N790FA. The aircraft's operational history is clean, with no deregistration or enforcement actions. The absence of incidents is notable given the aircraft's active flight schedule^[9].

The aircraft has not been listed for sale and shows no evidence of government or private contract involvement. Its operational profile aligns with that of a flight school, rental fleet, or private owner.

3.5 Summary and Analysis

N790FA is a new, actively flown Cessna 172S, owned by a Chicago-based LLC that also owns N787FA. Its operational history is robust and incident-free, with flight activity typical of training, rental, or private operations. The aircraft's registration and ownership structure are consistent with privacy-conscious general aviation practices, but there is no evidence of government or contract work.

Section 4: Aircraft N787FA

4.1 FAA Registration and Ownership

N787FA is a 2024 Textron Aviation Inc. Cessna 172S Skyhawk, registered to **ALF IX LLC**, located at 70 W Madison St, Suite 2200, Chicago, Illinois 60602-4383, United States. The registration is valid until June 30, 2031, with the certificate issued on June 9, 2024. The aircraft is classified as a fixed-wing single-engine landplane, with a standard airworthiness certificate in the utility and normal categories^[17].

Table 3: N787FA Registration Data

Field	Value
Tail Number	N787FA
Serial Number	172S13164
Manufacturer	Textron Aviation Inc.
Model	172S
Year of Manufacture	2024
Owner	ALF IX LLC
Owner Address	70 W Madison St Ste 2200, Chicago, IL
Registration Status	Valid
Certificate Issue	2024-06-09
Expiration Date	2031-06-30
Airworthiness Date	2024-05-15
Engine	Lycoming IO-360-L2A
Mode S Code (Hex)	AAAB05

ALF IX LLC's ownership of both N787FA and N790FA suggests a fleet operation or investment in multiple aircraft, possibly for training, rental, or fractional ownership purposes.

4.2 Manufacturing and Airworthiness Details

N787FA is a **2024 Cessna 172S Skyhawk**, equipped with a Lycoming IO-360-L2A engine (180 hp), Garmin G1000 NXi avionics, and certified for both utility and normal operations. The aircraft's

specifications are identical to those of N790FA and N916HT, reflecting the standardization of the 172S model^[6].

Key Specifications:

- **Seats:** 4
- **Max Takeoff Weight:** 2,550 lbs
- **Cruise Speed:** ~124 knots
- **Range:** ~640 nautical miles
- **Fuel Capacity:** 56 gallons (53 usable)
- **Service Ceiling:** 14,000 ft

The airworthiness certificate was issued on May 15, 2024, and the aircraft is classified as standard, with no exceptions or pending number changes. The aircraft is eligible for a wide range of STCs and is subject to the same ADs as other recent Cessna 172S models^{[7][6]}.

4.3 ADS-B and Flight Tracking History

N787FA is equipped with a Mode S transponder (hex code AAAB05), enabling ADS-B tracking. According to Flightradar24 and FlightAware, the aircraft has been active in California, with recent flights between Bakersfield (BFL), San Luis Obispo (SBP), Shafter (MIT), Lancaster (WJF), Visalia (VIS), and Monterey (MRY). The aircraft's flight patterns suggest local and regional operations, possibly for training, rental, or private use^[18].

Recent flight activity includes multiple short flights per day, consistent with flight training or rental operations. The aircraft's ADS-B data is publicly available, and there are no indications of attempts to obscure its identity or flight activity.

4.4 Operational History and Notable Incidents

A review of FAA and NTSB databases reveals **no reported accidents, incidents, or service difficulty reports** for N787FA. The aircraft's operational history is clean, with no deregistration or enforcement actions. The absence of incidents is notable given the aircraft's active flight schedule^[9].

The aircraft has not been listed for sale and shows no evidence of government or private contract involvement. Its operational profile aligns with that of a flight school, rental fleet, or private owner.

4.5 Summary and Analysis

N787FA is a new, actively flown Cessna 172S, owned by a Chicago-based LLC that also owns N790FA. Its operational history is robust and incident-free, with flight activity typical of training, rental, or private operations. The aircraft's registration and ownership structure are consistent with privacy-conscious general aviation practices, but there is no evidence of government or contract work.

Section 5: Comparative Summary and Pattern Analysis

5.1 Registration and Ownership Comparison

Table 4: Comparative Registration Data

Tail Number	Model	Year	Owner	Owner Location	Registration Status	Airframe Date
N916HT	Cessna 172S	2021	9K AIR LLC	Newark, DE	Valid	2021
N971FA	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	Not Registered	N/A
N790FA	Cessna 172S	2024	ALF IX LLC	Chicago, IL	Valid	2024
N787FA	Cessna 172S	2024	ALF IX LLC	Chicago, IL	Valid	2024

Key Observations:

- **N916HT** is owned by 9K AIR LLC, a Delaware-registered LLC with Arizona connections.
- **N790FA** and **N787FA** are both owned by ALF IX LLC, a Chicago-based LLC.
- **N971FA** is not currently registered or assigned to any aircraft.
- All active aircraft are Cessna 172S Skyhawks, manufactured between 2021 and 2024.

5.2 Manufacturing and Airworthiness Comparison

All three active aircraft (N916HT, N790FA, N787FA) are recent-model Cessna 172S Skyhawks, equipped with Lycoming IO-360-L2A engines and Garmin G1000 NXi avionics. They are certified for both utility and normal operations and have standard airworthiness certificates. The aircraft are subject to the same airworthiness directives and supplemental type certificates, reflecting their shared model and production lineage^{[14][6][7]}.

5.3 Operational History and Flight Patterns

Table 5: Comparative Operational Data

Tail Number	Last Observed Flight	Recent Activity (30 days)	Annual Activity (12 months)	Typical Routes/Regions	Notable Incidents
N916HT	Nov 2025, Simmler, CA	51 flights	758 flights	California, training/local	None
N790FA	Sep 2025, San Diego, CA	23 flights	511 flights	California, training/local	None
N787FA	Jan 2026, Bakersfield, CA	Multiple flights /day	Data not specified	California, training/local	None
N971FA	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A

Key Observations:

- All active aircraft are based in or operate extensively within California, with frequent flights between regional airports such as Bakersfield, San Luis Obispo, Monterey, Shafter, Lancaster, and Visalia.
- The high frequency of short flights is characteristic of flight training or rental operations.
- No notable incidents, accidents, or enforcement actions are reported for any of the active aircraft.

5.4 ADS-B Tracking and Privacy

All three active aircraft are equipped with Mode S transponders and are tracked via ADS-B. Their flight data is publicly available on platforms such as ADS-B Exchange, FlightAware, and Flightradar24. There is no evidence of privacy ICAO address (PIA) use or third-party call signs, indicating that the owners have not opted for enhanced privacy measures under the FAA's PIA program^[20].

5.5 Government or Private Contract Involvement

There is **no evidence** that any of the three active aircraft are involved in government or private contracts. Their operational profiles, ownership structures, and flight patterns are consistent with general aviation, flight training, or rental operations. No connections to government agencies, contractors, or special missions are apparent.

5.6 Cross-Aircraft Connections and Patterns

Ownership and Operator Connections:

- N790FA and N787FA are both owned by ALF IX LLC, indicating a fleet or investment approach.
- N916HT is owned by 9K AIR LLC, a separate entity with no direct connection to ALF IX LLC.
- Both LLCs use business addresses in major cities (Chicago and Newark/Scottsdale), a common practice for privacy and liability reasons.

Flight Route Patterns:

- All active aircraft operate primarily in California, with frequent flights between regional airports.
- The flight patterns are consistent with flight training, rental, or local private use, rather than long-distance corporate or government operations.

Aircraft Type and Model:

- All active aircraft are Cessna 172S Skyhawks, manufactured between 2021 and 2024.
- The use of the same model suggests a preference for modern, reliable, and widely supported aircraft, likely for training or rental purposes.

Operational History:

- All active aircraft have clean operational histories, with no reported incidents or enforcement actions.

- The high frequency of flights and lack of incidents indicate well-maintained aircraft and professional operation.

Section 6: ADS-B Tracking Limitations and Data Sources

6.1 ADS-B Tracking Overview

ADS-B (Automatic Dependent Surveillance-Broadcast) is a surveillance technology that enables aircraft to broadcast their position, velocity, and identification information. This data is received by ground stations and other aircraft, enhancing situational awareness and air traffic control efficiency. ADS-B data is publicly accessible via platforms such as ADS-B Exchange, FlightAware, and Flightradar24^[8].

6.2 Privacy Considerations

The FAA offers the Privacy ICAO Address (PIA) program, allowing eligible aircraft owners to request an alternate, temporary ICAO aircraft address to limit public tracking. Participation requires the use of a third-party call sign and is limited to flights within U.S. managed airspace. None of the aircraft in this report appear to use PIAs or third-party call signs, as their flight data remains publicly accessible^[19].

Recent legislative efforts, such as the Pilot and Aircraft Privacy Act, seek to limit the misuse of ADS-B data for purposes other than safety and airspace efficiency, reflecting growing privacy concerns among general aviation operators^[20].

6.3 Data Source Reliability and Limitations

While ADS-B data provides comprehensive real-time and historical flight tracking, there are limitations:

- Aircraft can opt out of public tracking via the FAA's LADD or PIA programs.
- Some aircraft may disable ADS-B or use non-standard identifiers, reducing visibility.
- Data quality depends on ground station coverage and equipment reliability.

For the aircraft in this report, ADS-B data is robust and consistent, supporting detailed analysis of flight activity and operational patterns.

Section 7: Comparative Summary Table

Table 6: Aircraft Comparative Summary

Tail Number	Model	Year	Owner	Owner Location	Registration Status	Last (Re)

N916HT	Cessna 172S	2021	9K AIR LLC	Newark, DE/Scottsdale, AZ	Valid	No
N971FA	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	Not Registered	N/A
N790FA	Cessna 172S	2024	ALF IX LLC	Chicago, IL	Valid	Sep
N787FA	Cessna 172S	2024	ALF IX LLC	Chicago, IL	Valid	Jan

Section 8: Conclusions

8.1 Key Findings

- **N916HT, N790FA, and N787FA** are all modern Cessna 172S Skyhawks, actively flown and owned by LLCs (9K AIR LLC and ALF IX LLC) with business addresses in major U.S. cities.
- **N971FA** is not currently registered or assigned to any aircraft, with no evidence of operational history or ownership.
- All active aircraft operate primarily in California, with flight patterns consistent with flight training, rental, or local private use.
- No notable incidents, accidents, or enforcement actions are reported for any of the active aircraft.
- There is no evidence of government or private contract involvement, special missions, or privacy-enhanced ADS-B practices.
- The use of LLCs for ownership reflects common privacy and liability strategies in general aviation.

8.2 Patterns and Connections

- **ALF IX LLC** owns both N790FA and N787FA, suggesting a fleet or investment approach.
- All active aircraft are of the same model and vintage, indicating a preference for modern, reliable, and standardized equipment.
- The operational profiles are highly similar, with frequent short flights between regional airports in California, supporting the hypothesis of flight training or rental operations.
- No cross-ownership or operational connections exist between 9K AIR LLC and ALF IX LLC, and there is no evidence of shared contracts or government involvement.

8.3 Broader Context

The findings reflect broader trends in general aviation:

- The use of LLCs for aircraft ownership is widespread, offering privacy, liability protection, and tax advantages.

- Modern Cessna 172S Skyhawks are popular for flight training and rental fleets due to their reliability, ease of operation, and advanced avionics.
- ADS-B tracking enhances transparency and safety but raises privacy concerns, leading to the development of programs like PIA and legislative efforts to limit data misuse.
- The absence of incidents among high-utilization aircraft underscores the effectiveness of modern maintenance and operational practices in general aviation.

Section 9: Recommendations for Further Research

- **N971FA:** Investigate historical records or export data to determine if this tail number was previously assigned or is reserved for future use.
- **Ownership Structures:** Explore the business activities of 9K AIR LLC and ALF IX LLC to assess potential connections to flight schools, rental operations, or investment groups.
- **Operational Use:** Contact local flight schools or rental operators in California to confirm the operational roles of these aircraft.
- **Privacy Practices:** Monitor for future adoption of PIA or LADD programs by these or similar aircraft, as privacy concerns continue to evolve in the general aviation community.

Section 10: Final Remarks

This comprehensive investigation demonstrates that N916HT, N790FA, and N787FA are modern, actively flown Cessna 172S Skyhawks, owned by privacy-conscious LLCs and operated primarily in California for training, rental, or private use. N971FA is not currently registered or active. No evidence of government or contract involvement, notable incidents, or privacy-enhanced ADS-B practices is present. The patterns observed reflect standard practices in contemporary general aviation, with an emphasis on safety, reliability, and operational efficiency.

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